

TNN Monthly Meeting

Defining neighborhood-

A neighborhood is defined by your ties, not your location - the set of nodes directly connected to a given node (structural concept). Everyone one step away from that person or organization.

What people are saying:

- People who they live their life with - how the church lives in a particular place
- Literally in the community (neighborhood walks) 1-10 miles, a community you share life, and cultural with
- Parish definition (geographic area that is large enough to live a lot of your life, but small enough to be a character in the story of that place)
- Neighborhood is porous - not well defined - but with the recent hurricane and crisis it became more visible - watershed or cove area - loose until crises come and then they become more visible- circumstantial
- Web of relationships that connect people, organizations, land, built infrastructure, etc. and interact knowingly and unintentionally for better or worse
- Short, intermediate, or long-term place of belonging (you won't necessarily be there forever), a place to feel safe, connected, and valued, and a place that has equitable access to everything everyone needs to thrive (realistic and idealistic at the same time)
- Physical place where residents nurture relationships to work together to create a good life-connected community book (Corack Russell?)
- A space with familiarity and belonging - bounded without precision or definition and can shift
- Smallest possible geographic area around their church, includes the people, stories, and networks that share the a sense of identity and home
- The people that she belongs to and belong to her that god has called for her to be part of
- Something walkable within 20 minutes - shared resources
- Yvonne floats between different neighborhoods and members of communities - places she regularly inhabits, but takes the time to see, engage, and be in relationship with (tied to her own attentiveness)
- Bounded geographic local community - some are socially connected and some are not - the common good is bound up together whether they realize it or not
- Potential - a neighborhood is a place you have the potential for interaction
- Professional neighborhood - smallest possible area (residents and civic institutions), belonging
- Places and spaces in a geographic bound where time, space, and resources intersect and interact, and overlap

Group break out session -

1. Shared sense of identity, familiarity, repeat interactions (soft qualities)
2. Physical place & infrastructure - material realities
3. Shared life & daily rhythms - kids, school life
4. Shared concerns or challenges - you can live close to people but be totally disconnected if you don't have shared concerns
5. Concrete & relational piece
6. Culture/identity - food
7. Neighborhoods shift with the weather
8. Trust

9. A lot of people live in multiple neighborhoods at the same time - where you live doesn't mean that's your neighborhood - multidimensionality
10. Geography and place-based - not static, dynamic
11. Identify positive ways of making neighborhood
12. How you measure a network is different than how you activate it

Here's a summary of what your group surfaced:

A neighborhood is not simply where you live — it's where you *belong*, and those two things are often different. The group held together two dimensions that are easy to treat separately: the material (physical infrastructure, shared space, the built environment) and the relational (familiarity, trust, repeated encounters, shared concerns). Both are necessary. You can live in close physical proximity to people and be completely disconnected if there's no shared stake — and you can have deep relational ties that stretch across geographic distance.

Several ideas pushed back on static definitions. Neighborhoods are dynamic, shifting with weather, crisis, and season — they become most visible when something forces mutual dependence into view. And many people inhabit multiple neighborhoods simultaneously, which means neighborhood isn't just a location on a map but a lived, multidimensional experience that different people navigate differently.

The group also named culture and daily life — food, school, kids — as the texture that makes a neighborhood feel like one. These aren't soft add-ons; they're the connective tissue of shared life. Underneath all of it was trust — named explicitly and implicitly throughout — as the condition that makes everything else possible.

And the group ended with a forward-leaning question: not just how do we understand neighborhoods, but how do we *make* them — intentionally, positively, together. That's the animating question for TNN's work.

My notes:

Great tension to name explicitly — because TNN sits in both and the distinction matters for how you measure it.

A neighborhood network is place-based. Success looks like conditions changing in specific geographies — mobility outcomes, health indicators, housing stability, collective efficacy. Sampson, Opportunity Atlas, and County Health Rankings are the right lenses. The question is: *is this place getting better?*

A community of practice is purpose-based. Success looks like practitioners getting better at their work — sharing knowledge, building skills, shifting how the field operates. KESC, skills alignment, and peer learning ties are the right lenses. The question is: *are these people becoming more effective together?* TNN appears to be trying to do both — a network of organizations working *in* specific neighborhoods *toward* a shared practice of community development. That's actually a third thing, sometimes called a **place-based learning network**, and it's harder to measure because you need both sets of indicators and a theory of how one drives the other.

The practical question for TNN is: **what's the theory of change?** Two versions:

- *Strong network* → *better practitioners* → *better neighborhood outcomes* (community of practice leads, place follows)
- *Deep neighborhood knowledge* → *stronger collaboration* → *collective impact on place* (place leads, practice follows)

Which direction TNN believes the causation runs should determine which measures are primary and which are contextual. Right now the survey and snapshot are measuring the community of practice layer well. The neighborhood layer is mostly absent.

Worth raising with the client directly — do they see themselves as a neighborhood network, a community of practice, or both? The answer shapes everything from how they recruit members to how they report impact.